

10.2 Optimising Images For The Web

Once you've finished editing your image, it's time to optimise it to minimise its size and hence the time it will take to download, while still keeping looking good, of course. The centre of operations for this activity is the Optimize palette, located in the top right corner of the ImageReady workspace. If you can't see it, select **Window > Optimize** to bring it up.

To see how the image will look once it's been optimised, use the Optimized, 2-Up or 4-Up tabs in the main document window.

10.2.1 How Indexed Colour Works

Before we begin, we need to understand how Indexed colour—used in the GIF format—works. We know that the colour of every pixel is defined by the Red, Green and Blue intensities. In the JPEG format, the level of each colour is represented by one byte—256 levels each of Red, Green and Blue, enabling 16 million possible colours.

To create GIF images, image editing programs create an *index* of 256 colours that will represent all the colours present in the image—either accurately or approximately, and then by assigning an index position, pixels will be matched to their colours. The index is often called a *Colour Table*.

This is a rough analogy of how this works:

Colour Table

No.	Colour
1	R=10, G=15, B=55
2	R=0, G=100, B=20

...and so on.

The Image

Pixel No.	Index Number
1	2
2	2
3	1

...and so on.



The Optimize Palette
for GIF Optimisation